

Maya and the cool spring

Cowboy story • 3-4 years old



Maya wore a wide hat. She rode a small brown horse named Dusty. The sun was warm on her face. The plain was wide and gold. Crows flew high. Blue sky spread like a big sheet.

Maya lived by a long, slow river. She loved the river. She loved the town at the bend. People came in wagons. They came tired and dusty. Maya saw them from her porch. She wanted to help.

One morning she heard wheels. "New folks!" she said. She put on her boots. She took a pitcher and a small wooden cup. Dusty neighed. "Let's go," said Maya.

The road was bumpy. Maya and Dusty rode fast. They crossed a dry field. They jumped a little stream. Maya held the pitcher tight. The sun was hot. Her hat shaded her eyes. She thought of cool water.

At the wagons, people smiled but looked hot. A boy wiped his brow. A mother had a baby on her lap. The father tipped his hat. Their horses drank from a bucket, but the people needed water too.

Maya set the pitcher down. "Fresh water," she said. "Come and drink." The mother came first. The baby laughed and reached. The boy took a big long sip. "Ah," he said. "That is good." The father smiled. "Thank you," he said.

Then a big wind blew. Dusty shied. A cloth flew from a wagon. A box slid off the back. Maya stepped fast. She held the pitcher with one hand and grabbed the box with the other. "Careful," she said. The father ran to help. Together they set the box back. The mother tied the cloth again.

"Can you find more water?" asked the father. They had more miles to go. Maya nodded. "I know a spring," she said. She led the way. The road climbed a small hill. Maya walked with the pitcher now. Dusty walked slow beside her. The town was far behind.

At the top of the hill, a little path led to a cool place. Maya knew the path. Tiny flowers nodded. A robin sang. The spring bubbled from the ground like a soft

song. Water shone in the light. Maya filled the pitcher. The cup was full and bright.

On the way back, the boy ran ahead. He held the cup like a prize. "We will remember this," he said. The mother hugged him. The father patted Dusty. "You are brave," he told Maya. Maya smiled. She felt warm inside.

They reached the wagons as the sun began to dip. People laughed and talked. They ate bread and dipped cups in the cool water. The sky turned orange and pink. Stars began to wink.

Maya sat on her porch that night. Dusty munched hay. The town was quiet and kind. Maya looked at the river. She was tired but happy. She had helped new friends. She had given them water and a warm smile.

"Good night," she said softly. The wind answered like a lullaby. Maya closed her eyes. All was safe and calm.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What is the girl's name?

- Maya
- Sophie
- Anna
- Lily

2) What is the horse's name?

- Dusty
- Star
- Sunny
- Blue

3) What did Maya bring to the new people?

- Water in a pitcher
- A big toy
- A warm blanket
- A basket of apples

4) Where did Maya get more water?

- From a spring on the hill
- From a shop
- From the river in town
- From the sky

Correct answers:

1) Maya 2) Dusty 3) Water in a pitcher 4) From a spring on the hill

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Plain: A wide, open area with grass and no trees.

Porch: A small outside part of a house where you can sit.

Pitcher: A tall container used to hold and pour water.

Wagons: Big carts pulled by animals to carry people or things.

Neighed: The loud sound a horse makes.

Bumpy: Not smooth, with little rises and falls.

Shaded: Kept cool by being out of the bright sun.

Spring: A place where water comes out from the ground.

Bubbled: Made many small round pops in the water.

Dip: To move down a little, like the sun going lower.

Wink: To close and open one eye fast, like a small light.

Lullaby: A soft song sung to help a child sleep.

Munched: Ate something slowly with small chewing sounds.